

Capital One

Money Milestones

A financial confidence layer for young adults ages 18 to 24

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1. Executive Summary

Capital One serves teens through its MONEY account, with parental oversight and savings goals, and serves adults through full featured checking, savings, AutoSave, and credit products. Between them sits an underserved moment: the 18 to 24 year old who is newly financially independent, often a college student or early earner with variable income, learning to budget, build credit, and save for the first time without a parent's hand on the account.

Money Milestones is an in app financial confidence layer for this segment. It combines a gamified set of financial literacy milestones, budgeting tuned for irregular student income, beginner friendly credit building guidance, and small automated savings nudges, meeting young adults at the exact moment money habits form.

Why now

Winning the 18 to 24 relationship early is one of the highest lifetime value opportunities in consumer banking. This cohort is forming the primary banking and credit habits that persist for decades. A confidence building experience deepens engagement, accelerates adoption of Capital One savings and credit products, and builds loyalty before competitors capture the relationship.

2. Problem Statement

User problem

Young adults entering financial independence face a steep, unguided learning curve. They juggle irregular income from part time and gig work, do not know how to start building credit safely, feel anxious about money, and find that most banking apps assume a stable paycheck and existing financial fluency. Generic savings goals do not teach the underlying habits or confidence this group is missing.

Business problem

Banks compete fiercely for the young adult relationship because it sets the default for decades of deposits, credit, and lending. Capital One has strong teen and adult products but no purpose built

bridge for the independence transition, which risks losing this cohort to fintech challengers that target it directly.

3. User Personas

Persona	Snapshot	Primary pain point
The New Grad (Jordan, 22)	First job with irregular early income and student loans starting.	Never learned budgeting and feels anxious about credit.
The Working Student (Maya, 19)	Part time income that changes week to week on a tight budget.	Income varies, so fixed budget templates break immediately.
The First Generation Saver (Carlos, 20)	No family financial roadmap to follow.	Does not know where to start and fears costly mistakes.
The Credit Curious (Tasha, 23)	Wants a strong score to qualify for an apartment lease.	Confused about how credit actually works and what helps.

4. Goals and Success Metrics

Qualitative goals

- Build genuine financial confidence and durable habits.
- Make Capital One the trusted first money app for this generation.
- Bridge the gap between the teen MONEY product and full adult banking.

Quantitative targets

Metric	Baseline	Target	Measurement
Users completing 3 or more milestones	0%	45%	Feature telemetry
90 day retention (18 to 24 segment)	Baseline	+12%	Cohort analysis
AutoSave adoption within segment	TBD	+20%	Product analytics
Self reported financial confidence	Baseline	+15 points	In app survey
Cross product adoption in 6 months	TBD	+18%	Product analytics

- **North Star metric:** active young adults completing a money habit (budget set, save, or credit step) each month.

5. Scope

In scope

- Gamified financial literacy milestones that are short and interactive.
- A budgeting flow built for variable income, using percentages rather than fixed amounts.
- Beginner credit building education and secured card guidance.
- Small automated savings nudges tied to milestones.
- A confidence and progress dashboard, plus segment specific onboarding.

Out of scope

- Lending decisions or underwriting changes.
- Investment or brokerage features.
- Rebuilding the teen MONEY product.
- Financial advice that requires a licensed advisor.
- Any redesign of core checking and savings.

6. Functional Requirements

ID	Requirement	Priority
FR1	Segment specific onboarding that assesses goals and income pattern.	Must Have
FR2	A library of short, interactive financial literacy milestones with progress tracking.	Must Have
FR3	A budgeting flow designed for irregular income, using percentage based allocation.	Must Have
FR4	A beginner credit building module explaining score factors and safe first steps.	Should Have
FR5	A guided path to a Capital One secured or starter card where appropriate.	Should Have
FR6	Small automated savings nudges tied to milestones, such as saving a first \$50.	Should Have
FR7	A confidence and progress dashboard for the user.	Should Have
FR8	Celebratory moments and shareable milestone badges.	Nice to Have
FR9	Optional mentor and content tie in via the Financial Success Hub.	Nice to Have

7. Non Functional Requirements

- **Compliance:** all credit and financial guidance is reviewed for regulatory accuracy under truth in lending and fair lending standards, with no misleading claims and clear separation of education from personalized advice.
- **Accessibility:** meets WCAG AA and uses plain language at an approachable reading level.
- **Trust and tone:** encouraging and never condescending, with transparency about any product recommendation.
- **Performance:** milestones load instantly and run well on lower end devices common in this segment.
- **Privacy:** minimal data collection for personalization, with clear consent.

8. Risks and Assumptions

Risks

- **Sales funnel perception:** the feature could read as a push toward credit products. Mitigate with genuine education first and transparent recommendations.
- **Regulatory exposure:** financial guidance carries compliance and reputational risk and must be reviewed carefully.
- **Shallow engagement:** milestones risk feeling like homework. Mitigate with relevance, brevity, and meaningful rewards.

- **Trust sensitivity:** this cohort is skeptical of banks and quick to disengage if the experience feels inauthentic.

Assumptions

- Young adults want guidance, not just tools.
- Gamified literacy improves real behavior and product adoption.
- Bridging teen to adult banking is a defensible differentiator.
- The lifetime value of this cohort justifies the investment.

9. Proposed Timeline

Phase	Focus	Duration
Discovery	Segment research and journey mapping for the independence transition.	4 weeks
Content and compliance design	Milestones, budgeting logic, and credit modules with legal review.	6 weeks
Build (alpha)	Onboarding, milestones, and variable income budgeting.	8 weeks
Beta	Credit module and savings nudges.	5 weeks
GA launch	Phased rollout with monitoring.	3 weeks

10. Open Questions

- How do we balance authentic education against the commercial pull to cross sell credit products?
- What is the right incentive for milestone completion without trivializing money habits?
- Should this live as a distinct in app space or be woven into the existing home experience?
- How do we measure real behavior change rather than just in app engagement?
- Do we build a guided handoff from the teen MONEY account when a user turns 18?

11. Appendix

- **Market context:** Capital One already offers MONEY for teens, AutoSave and AutoPilot, and the Financial Success Hub; automated personal finance is a named 2026 banking trend.
- **Related features:** 360 Performance Savings, secured cards, and the Money and Life mentoring program.
- **Compliance references:** truth in lending, fair lending, and advertising standards.
- **Glossary:** secured card, credit utilization, variable income budgeting, lifetime value.